Where to get shells

There are a variety of sources of different shells. With the popularity of the sputnik sea urchin shells for ornaments, you may find these shells in your local woodturning retailer. If not there, they are readily available from the shell dealers via the internet. The variety of sizes, shapes and colours will give you plenty to choose from for your needs. Egg shells are available from many sources. If you are working with chicken egg shells, your source can be your local grocer or nearby farm. If you can get chicken eggs from your farmer, you'll not only have far better eating, but superior shells to work with. The shells will be thicker and more durable than those from the mass producers. My method for cleaning shells for use doesn't allow me to reclaim the egg mass for cooking but I can certainly appreciate the quality difference of those I use for cooking. If you are cleaning your chicken eggs, you'll find information on many different methods of 'blowing' the eggs online. I favour the single hole method, but you are welcome to use any method you prefer. Virtually all other shells are available for purchase already cleaned and ready for use. If your local retailer doesn't have urchin shells in their various sizes or colours or duck, goose, emu and ostrich eggs, you can find sources for these via the internet. Other than my chicken eggs, I get all of my other shells cleaned and ready for use from an internet supplier.

Plenty of types of shell are available at your grocer, turning retailer or on the internet

Start with chicken eggs, which are readily available, inexpensive and easily prepared for use

What can you do with them?

There are a host of things you can do with the different types of shell material available. One of interest that we won't be able to cover this month is using crushed and broken shell as a mask. The different shell material with the unique broken sizes and shapes can be bonded to other turnings temporarily to shield that work from torching or painting. The protective shell can then be removed leaving that uniqueness underneath unaltered by the burning or painting process. We'll explore that in a future article. This month, let's focus on using the shell materials as a part of our turning. The two most straightforward applications are ornaments and lidded boxes. Both of these applications can incorporate either unaltered or adorned shells.

FAR RIGHT: An easily made chicken egg shell ornament with some spray paint, self-stick appliqué and turned finials

RIGHT: A sea urchin shell lidded box with a choice of two lids, simple turnings and one glue joint

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